

are such stuff as dreams are made on, and our little life is rounded with a sleep . . .'

'That was very poetic.'

'The Spanish dramatist *Calderón de la Barca*, who was born in the year 1600, wrote a play called *Life Is a Dream*, in which he says: "What is life? A madness. What is life? An illusion, a shadow, a story, and the greatest good is little enough, for all life is a dream . . ."

'He may be right. We read a play at school. It was called *Jeppe on the Mount*.'

'By *Ludvig Holberg*, yes. He was a gigantic figure here in Scandinavia, marking the transition from the Baroque period to the Age of Enlightenment.'

'*Jeppe* falls asleep in a ditch . . . and wakes up in the Baron's bed. So he thinks he only dreamed that he was a poor farmhand. Then when he falls asleep again they carry him back to the ditch, and he wakes up again. This time he thinks he only dreamed he was lying in the Baron's bed.'

'Holberg borrowed this theme from *Calderón*, and *Calderón* had borrowed it from the old Arabian tales, *A Thousand and One Nights*. Comparing life to a dream, though, is a theme we find even farther back in history, not least in India and China. The old Chinese sage *Chuang-tzu*, for example, said: Once I dreamed I was a butterfly, and now I no longer know whether I am *Chuang-tzu*, who dreamed I was a butterfly, or whether I am a butterfly dreaming that I am *Chuang-tzu*.'

'Well, it was impossible to prove either way.'

'We had in Norway a genuine Baroque poet called *Petter Dass*, who lived from 1647 to 1707. On the one hand he was concerned with describing life as it is here and now, and on the other hand he emphasized that only God is eternal and constant.'

'God is God if every land was waste, God is God if every man were dead.'

'But in the same hymn he writes about rural life in Northern Norway—and about lumpfish, cod, and coalfish. This is a typical Baroque feature, describing in the same text the earthly and the here and now—and the celestial and the hereafter. It is all very reminiscent of Plato's distinction between the concrete world of the senses and the immutable world of ideas.'

'What about their philosophy?'

'That too was characterized by powerful struggles between diametrically opposed modes of thought. As I have already mentioned, some philosophers believed that what exists is at bottom spiritual in